

ولو كان يملك معرفة الرجوع

“Even If It Knows the Way Back”

How the Dangerous Animal Traveled Through Arab Law

The words in red appear in the Emirati law of 2016, the Egyptian law of 2023 and the Bahraini law of 2026.
Companion tool: Law X-ray.

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1 Summary

Egyptian law calls one kind of animal “abandoned” and then defines it without any mention of abandonment. We followed that clue through four Arab laws on keeping dangerous animals: the United Arab Emirates in 2016, Qatar in 2019, Egypt in 2023 and Bahrain in 2026.

Using a method we call statutory attribution, we measured how much text the four laws share, dividing each into nine comparable provisions and counting the five-word sequences that appear word for word in an earlier law.

Qatar's law, drafted separately, shares about 1 percent with each of the others, and that figure is our baseline. Egypt's law shares 9 percent of its measured text with the Emirati law, and 22 percent of its definitions. Six of its eleven definitions contain Emirati text, and two are taken word for word. Among them are the definitions of the stray and the abandoned animal, on which Egypt's response to street animals rests. Bahrain's law shares 20 percent of its measured text with the Emirati law. For one provision, the duty to report a dangerous animal, Bahrain followed Egypt's wording rather than the Emirati original. The text traveled from the Emirates to Egypt and Bahrain, and at least one provision traveled from Egypt to Bahrain.

The category these laws share is older than any of them. The 1900 London Convention, signed by the European colonial powers but never brought into force, set out to protect the wild animals it judged useful to people or harmless, and listed others as harmful, to be reduced in number. Seven of its ten harmful groups appear in Egypt's 2023 list. Three animals it listed for protection because of their rarity, the gorilla, the chimpanzee and the wild ass, now appear on the same Egyptian list as three breeds of dog.

The laws answer the dangerous animal with a license. Under the Emirati, Egyptian and Bahraini laws, zoos, animal parks and circuses may be licensed to keep, breed and trade these animals. Egypt's 2025 regulation follows the Emirati regulation of 2019 closely, but differs in two places. It leaves out the Emirati register of where each animal came from, and it narrows the Emirati way back for a seized animal, rehabilitation and return to its natural environment, to native animals surrendered in a transitional period.

Each of the four lists can be revised by the responsible ministry, as Egypt's was in 2025, so these findings bear on the next revision.

2 Key Terms

Dangerous animal. In three of the four laws, an animal the state names on an official list because of the harm it can cause to people or to other animals. Qatar's law uses the list alone.

License. Written permission from a government authority to keep a dangerous animal, and in most of these laws to breed or trade it. For anyone the law does not exempt, keeping such an animal without a license is an offense in all four states.

Legal transplant. The movement of a legal rule from one country's law into another's. Alan Watson made the term central to comparative law in 1974, arguing that borrowing is the most fertile source of legal development. In the same year, Otto Kahn-Freund warned that a borrowed rule may not fit the country that receives it.

Alan Watson, *Legal Transplants* (1974). Otto Kahn-Freund, “On Uses and Misuses of Comparative Law,” *Modern Law Review* 37 (1974): 1.

Stemma. A family tree of texts, built from the changes that copies share. Textual scholars have drawn stemmas since the nineteenth century to show which manuscript was copied from which.

CITES. The Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora, a 1973 treaty that controls trade across borders in the species listed in its appendices. All four states are parties.

3 A Mismatch in Article 1

Article 1 of Egypt's 2023 law calls one kind of animal “abandoned.” It then defines it as an animal that wanders freely outside the place where its keeper houses it, without the keeper's restraint or supervision, even if it knows the way back. Nothing in the definition requires that anyone abandoned it. The word and its definition do not match.

We first read this law closely for our first investigation, which concerned Article 23, the article that directs the state's response to stray and abandoned animals that pose a danger. A definition that does not fit its name may have been written under another name. This paper follows that clue.

In four Arab states, whether a person may keep many wild species is now decided by one legal category: the dangerous animal. The category decides which species need a license, which places may hold them, and what happens to an animal the state seizes. Three of the four laws define it by the harm an animal can cause to people or to other animals; the fourth, Qatar's, gives no criterion at all. No definition asks whether a species is rare, native or protected by treaty.

The lists behind the category are open. The Emirati ministry may add species to its annexes or remove them. Qatar's minister may amend its table by decision. Egypt's minister may amend its tables on the proposal of the General Organization for Veterinary Services, and did so in May 2025, cutting the dangerous dog breeds on the list from sixteen to three. Bahrain's law, issued on 3 June 2026, leaves its list to a ministerial decision approved by the Council of Ministers. The warning in the literature on legal transplants applies here: a rule revised without knowing where it came from carries its assumptions forward.

Egypt's law also names its own measure: it applies without prejudice to the international conventions to which Egypt is a party, CITES among them. In Egypt's own text, a category that sorts wild animals by the harm they can cause meets a treaty that sorts them by the threat trade poses to their survival.

4 How We Read the Four Laws

We read and measured the four laws in the original Arabic. For the rules on licenses and seizures, we also read the Emirati regulation of 2019 and the Egyptian regulation of 2025. The sources are listed in Annex C.

We divided each law into nine provisions, each found in at least two of the laws. They are the definitions, the ban and the license, the duties of a keeper, the public's duty to report a loose or unlicensed animal, the keeper's duty to notify the authority, births, seizure, public places, and the penalties for an attack. Where a law has no such provision, that comparison was left out.

For each pair of laws, we took the later law and asked one question: what share of its five-word sequences appears, word for word, in the earlier law? Five words is long enough that a match rarely happens by chance, and short enough to catch a clause taken with small edits. We also recorded the longest passage that appears unchanged in both laws. As a check, we repeated the count with three-word sequences. The ranking of the pairs did not change.

The method joins three ways of reading. The first is Giovanni Morelli's. In

Law No. 29 of 2023, Article 1

الحيوان المتروك: الحيوان الذي يتجول بحريته خارج
مكان إيوائه بدون قيد وإشراف من حائزه ولو كان
يملك معرفة الرجوع إلى مكان حيازته وإيوائه.

Decree No. 218 of 2025, Al-Waqa'i' al-Misriyya
No. 106 (follow-up), 13 May 2025. See the note in
Annex C.

the nineteenth century he attributed paintings by their earlobes and fingernails, the details a copyist reproduces without thinking, and Carlo Ginzburg later showed that the same habit of mind runs through medicine and detective work. The second is the stemma, defined in section 2. The third is measurement: in 2016, Wolfgang Alschner and Dmitriy Skougarevskiy used textual similarity to map more than 2,100 investment treaties and to trace which states wrote the language that others adopted. We call the combination statutory attribution. As far as we could find, none of the three has been applied to Arab animal law before.

Qatar's law, on the same subject, in the same region and decade, gives the baseline: about 1 percent shared with each of the others. A figure well above that points to borrowing.

The measure has limits, and we state them. It counts shared words, and cannot see a borrowed idea set in new words. Egypt's definition of trade, for example, lists much the same operations as the Emirati one, including the loan of an animal, yet shares almost no wording with it. Some shared phrases are ordinary legal wording rather than borrowing, which is why we rely on the baseline and on long unchanged passages. We also looked for a Gulf or Arab model law on dangerous animals that the three could have drawn on separately, and found none. The measure shows shared text, and dates show which text came first, since a law cannot borrow from one passed after it. Neither shows who drafted the text. We found no drafting document that names the Emirati law as a source, so the evidence here is textual. The species lists are tables of names, so we compare them by name in section 6.

Annex B gives every count, and the texts and the script are published with this paper, so any reader can repeat the measurement.

5 One Text, Four Countries

Three of the four laws share a text, and the text moved outward from the Emirates.

For most of the twentieth century, law in the region traveled the other way. The Egyptian Civil Code of 1948, drafted under Abd al-Razzaq al-Sanhuri, became the model for civil codes across the Arab world, and in 1985 Ian Edge could write that Egyptian jurists had been the main legal draftsmen of the Gulf. Here the text moves from the Gulf to Egypt.

Egypt's 2023 law shares 9 percent of its measured text with the Emirati law of 2016, far above the baseline. The borrowing is concentrated in the definitions, where the figure rises to 22 percent. Six of Egypt's eleven definitions contain Emirati text, and two are taken word for word. The definition of an animal park, nineteen words long, is identical in both laws. The definition of breeding, "any activity to increase the breeding of dangerous animals," is the Emirati definition without its first two words.

Press reports date part of this borrowing. When the agriculture committee of the House of Representatives approved the bill in its final form, it added two definitions, one of them the animal park: the Emirati text.

Bahrain's 2026 law shares 20 percent of its measured text with the Emirati law. Its definitions share 26 percent, and its penalties for attacks 34 percent. The longest passage the two laws share unchanged runs to twenty-seven words, across the definitions of loose and stray animals.

Bahrain did not draw on the Emirates alone. The Emirati law sets out two separate duties: whoever finds a loose or stray dangerous animal must report it, and whoever knows of one held without a license must report that. Egypt merged the two into a single sentence. Bahrain's law uses Egypt's merged sentence rather than the two Emirati ones. Half of the five-word sequences in Bahrain's provision match Egypt's, against a

Carlo Ginzburg, "Clues: Roots of an Evidential Paradigm," in *Clues, Myths, and the Historical Method* (1989). Wolfgang Alschner and Dmitriy Skougarevskiy, *Journal of International Economic Law* 19 (2016): 561.

Law X-ray, the companion tool, carries the texts and the script. It is linked from Animal Crime Bureau's Substack, animalcrimebureau.substack.com.

Ian Edge, "Comparative Commercial Law of Egypt and the Arabian Gulf," *Cleveland State Law Review* 34 (1985 to 1986): 129.

Identical wording in both laws, Article 1

المتنزهات الحيوانية: حدائق ذات مساحة واسعة
تتيح للحيوان حرية الحركة وتحاكي بيئته الطبيعية
وتمكن الزائر من الزيارة والتجول ضمن مربعات
مخصصة.

Egypt, Law No. 29 of 2023, Article 8

يتعين على كل من يجد أياً من الحيوانات الخطرة
متروكاً أو ضالاً، وعلى كل من يعلم بوجود حيوان
خطر غير مرخص بمخازنه لدى أى حائز إبلاغ
السلطة المختصة لاتخاذ التدابير والإجراءات اللازمة.

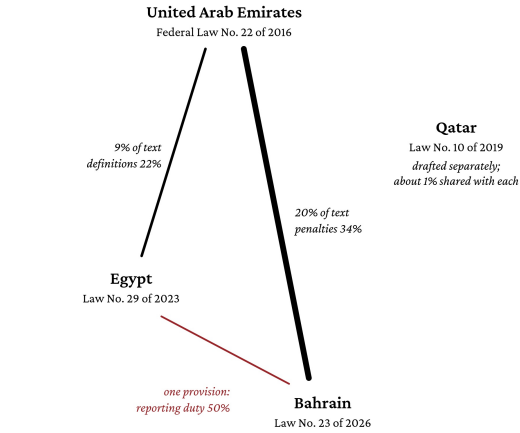
tenth for the Emirati text, and fourteen consecutive words are identical. On this evidence, Egypt both received the text and passed it on.

Bahrain, Law No. 23 of 2026, Article 7(a)

تعيين على كل من يجد أيًا من الحيوانات الخطرة
سائباً أو ضالاً أو متخلى عنه، وعلى كل من يعلم
بوجود حيوان خطر غير مرخص بمحاذته لدى أي
حائز، إبلاغ الوزارة لاتخاذ التدابير والإجراءات
اللازمة.

Figure 1

Egypt and Bahrain drew on the Emirati text. Qatar drafted its own.



Line width shows the share of the later law's five-word sequences found in the earlier law, across the nine provisions compared (Annex B). The red line marks one provision, the reporting duty, which Egypt merged from two Emirati articles and Bahrain adopted in its merged form. Like any family tree of texts, this one is a hypothesis.

Animal Crime Bureau, Working Paper No. 2, ACB/WP/002

Not everything traveled. Egypt wrote its own penalties, which share 2 percent of their wording with the Emirati ones. Bahrain took the structure of the Emirati penalties, often in the same words. The category also changed hands on the way. In the Emirates and in Qatar, the law is run by the ministry responsible for the environment. In Egypt it is run by the General Organization for Veterinary Services, and in Bahrain by the ministry responsible for livestock.

Its purpose changed as well. When the Emirati Federal National Council debated the bill in 2016, it spoke of dangerous animals that escape or are abandoned, of falling numbers and extinction, of harm to biodiversity, and of danger to people nearby. Egypt's joint committee report of 2023 presented the bill as an answer to social phenomena that threaten public security, among them dogs made vicious and used to frighten people or commit crimes. The same words were put to a different use.

This explains the mismatch in section 3. The Emirati law defines two kinds of animal outside a keeper's control. A loose animal (*sa'ib*) is one that nobody owns and that lives on its own. A stray animal (*dall*) is one that wanders freely without its keeper's restraint, even if it knows its way home. Egypt kept both definitions and moved the names. In the Egyptian law, the unowned animal living on its own is the stray (*dall*). The animal that has a keeper but wanders from the keeper's control is the abandoned animal (*matruk*). Bahrain kept the Emirati names and added a third term, for an owned animal that its keeper leaves without care, deliberately or through neglect. The Egyptian word and its definition do not match because the definition was written first, in another law, under another name. This is the kind of detail Morelli relied on: a feature carried over without thought, which shows where a text was first made.

Al Bayan, 25 May 2016, on the Federal National Council debate. Youm7, 30 April 2023, text of the joint committee report.

Figure 2

The definitions traveled. The names moved.

A. The animal that nobody owns and that lives on its own

United Arab Emirates, 2016

الحيوان السائب:

الحيوان غير المملوك الذي يوجد في موقع ما
معتمداً على ذاته وغير خاضع لسيطرة ورعاية أي حائز.

Egypt, 2023

الحيوان الضال:

الحيوان غير المملوك وغير الخاضع لسيطرة ورعاية أي حائز،
ويوجد في موقع ما معتمداً على ذاته.

B. The animal that has a keeper but roams free

United Arab Emirates, 2016

الحيوان الضال:

الحيوان الذي يتجول بحريته بدون قيد وإشراف من حائزه
ولو كان يملك معرفة الرجوع إلى مكان حيازته.

Egypt, 2023

الحيوان المتروك:

الحيوان الذي يتجول بحريته خارج مكان إيوائه
بدون قيد وإشراف من حائزه ولو كان يملك
معرفة الرجوع إلى مكان حيازته وإيوائه.

Red marks what Egypt changed: the names, and in B, the words it added. In A, Egypt reordered the Emirati clauses and changed their form slightly; the wording is otherwise the same. Bahrain's 2026 law keeps the Emirati names. Sources: Federal Law No. 22 of 2016, Article 1; Law No. 29 of 2023, Article 1.

Animal Crime Bureau, Working Paper No. 2, ACB/WP/002

In committee, the head of Egypt's federation of animal welfare associations objected that the definition of the stray animal would cover a street dog already sterilized and vaccinated. The minister for parliamentary affairs answered that animals in the care of civil society are not stray. The definition was enacted in substance as the committee reviewed it. It now shapes Article 23 of the Egyptian law, which directs the state's measures toward stray and abandoned animals that pose a danger, and which was the subject of ACB's first investigation report. The words that Egyptian law uses for its street animals were first written in the Emirates, in a law on dangerous animals.

6 An Older Category

As a statutory category, the dangerous animal is recent in Arab law, dating from 2016. The idea behind it is older. It sorts animals by their relation to people, and that way of sorting has a written history in colonial Africa.

On 19 May 1900, Britain, Germany, Spain, the Congo Free State, France, Italy and Portugal signed a convention in London on the wild animals of their African possessions. Its preamble set out to preserve the wild animals “which are either useful to man or are harmless.” Its first schedule listed two groups for full protection: animals useful to people, such as vultures and owls, and animals listed “on account of their rarity,” including the gorilla, the chimpanzee and the wild ass. Its fifth schedule named the “harmful animals” whose numbers governments should reduce: the lion, the leopard, hyenas, the African wild dog, the otter, baboons and other “harmful monkeys,” large birds of prey, crocodiles, poisonous snakes and pythons.

Seven of those ten harmful groups appear in Egypt's 2023 list of dangerous animals: the lion, the leopard, hyenas, baboons with other monkeys, crocodiles, poisonous snakes and pythons. Of the other three, the otter and the birds of prey are absent, since Egypt's list contains no birds, and the African wild dog is not named, though the list covers wolves. The three animals the convention listed for protection because of their rarity also appear in Egypt's list. The gorilla, the chimpanzee and the wild ass now share a table with three breeds of dog.

British Parliamentary Papers, 1900, Cd. 101. On its failure to enter into force: Peter H. Sand, *European Journal of International Law* 8 (1997): 29.

Figure 3
Seven of the ten groups the 1900 convention called harmful are on Egypt's list of dangerous animals.

1900 convention, fifth schedule: harmful animals	Egypt's list of dangerous animals, 2023	
Lion	Lions	الأسود
Leopard	Leopards	الفهود
Hyenas	Hyenas	فصيلة الضباع
African wild dog	Not named	
Otter	Not listed	
Baboons and other monkeys	Baboons, monkeys	البابون، النسانيس
Large birds of prey	No birds listed	
Crocodiles	Crocodiles	القناصيح
Poisonous snakes	Venomous snakes	الثعابين السامة
Pythons	Pythons	الاصلات
1900 convention, first schedule: protected for rarity	Egypt's list of dangerous animals, now	
Gorilla	Gorilla	الغوريلا
Chimpanzee	Chimpanzee	الشبانزي
Wild asses	Wild donkeys	الخير البرية

Red marks animals on Egypt's list. The list covers the wolf family but does not name the African wild dog, and it lists no birds. A 2025 amendment to the Egyptian list changed its dog breeds. The 1900 convention never came into force and did not cover Egypt. Sources: Convention for the Preservation of Wild Animals, Birds, and Fish in Africa, London, 1900, first and fifth schedules; Law No. 29 of 2023, Table 1; Decree No. 1731 of 2025, schedule of license fees.

Animal Crime Bureau, Working Paper No. 2, ACB/WP/002

This is not a claim that Egypt inherited the list by treaty. The 1900 convention never entered into force, and the zone it covered began south of Egypt, at the twentieth parallel. The point is the persistence of a way of sorting. Egypt did take part in the next attempt. It ratified the 1933 London Convention on the preservation of fauna and flora on 21 February 1935, and the convention bound Egypt from 14 January 1936. Recent work on African wildlife law has traced the design of today's national statutes back to that convention.

Human-animal studies has a name for this way of sorting. In 1996, Arnold Arluke and Clinton Sanders called it the sociozoologic scale. Biology ranks animals by what they are. The sociozoologic scale ranks them, in their words, “according to how well they seem to fit in” with the roles people expect of them. The schedules of 1900 and the Egyptian table of 2023 are legal forms of that scale. The colonial treaty kept a second measure beside usefulness: rarity. In the laws that define it, the dangerous animal keeps only harm.

Harm as a legal category also has a history in Islamic law, which knows the fawasiq: in the best-known narration, five animals the Prophet allowed to be killed even within the sacred precinct of Mecca, a permission jurists explain by the harm the animals do. They are the crow, the kite, the scorpion, the mouse and the biting dog. They are everyday animals, and the rule permits killing them. The modern list holds lions, great apes and crocodiles, and its rule is a license to keep them. In its members, the dangerous animal stands closer to the schedule of 1900; its license comes from the design discussed next.

The licensing design has a closer precedent in Britain's Dangerous Wild Animals Act of 1976: a list of kinds, a license from the local authority to keep one, and, as enacted, exemptions for zoos, circuses, pet shops and scientific establishments. The Emirati, Egyptian and Bahraini laws share the list, the license and the special place of zoos and circuses. We found no document showing that the Emirati drafters worked from the British Act, so we report a resemblance of design only.

Britain has since withdrawn the circus exemption, in England and Scotland from January 2020 and in Wales from December 2020. The Emirati law of 2016, the Egyptian law of 2023 with its 2025 regulation,

League of Nations Treaty Series No. 3995, status in the United Nations Treaty Collection. F. Dermillah Obare, *Journal of International Wildlife Law & Policy* (2026).

Arnold Arluke and Clinton R. Sanders, *Regarding Animals* (1996), 169.

Sahih al-Bukhari, hadith 1829

نحس من الدواب، كلهن فاسق، يقتلهن في الحرم:
الغراب، والحدأة، والعقرب، والفأرة، والكلب
العقور

and the Bahraini law of 2026 all allow circuses to be licensed.

7 What the Category Does to a Wild Animal

Once the law calls an animal dangerous, three things follow. It may be licensed into captivity. In Egypt, its license asks about its care and not about its origin. And the way back that the Emirati rules give a seized animal is narrower in Egypt.

In Egypt, the law allows public bodies, research institutions, zoos, animal parks, circuses and specialized centers to hold dangerous animals under license. The 2025 regulation defines those centers to include facilities that keep the animals to care for, breed, rehabilitate or trade them. It names the purposes a license may serve: sheltering the animal in a licensed center, breeding it, using it in shows and circuses, or using it in research, along with any other purpose the authority sets by decision. The license runs for one year, and the regulation prices it by kind of animal: 5,000 Egyptian pounds a year for a gorilla or a chimpanzee, and 1,000 for a fox or a wolf.

The license asks about care. The transplant also continued below the statute. Egypt's 2025 regulation follows the Emirati regulation of 2019 closely. Its first requirement repeats the Emirati wording on the species to be held and the capacity “for parents and young,” and its records repeat the Emirati records of births and deaths, health and vaccination, feeding, cleaning and rodent control. It leaves out the Emirati register of each animal's identifying details and of its purchases and sales, “including the sources of the animals and the buyers,” with copies of the proof. Where the Emirati rule asks for a file of CITES certificates, the Egyptian rule asks for a special file on CITES-listed animals “as applicable,” without saying what it contains. Nothing else in the Egyptian file or records asks where an animal came from. Without that question, a license cannot tell a lawfully acquired animal from one that was not. Qatar's law also requires every sale or purchase of a dangerous animal to be entered in a register kept by the ministry.

Animals born in captivity need no separate license. Under the Egyptian law, each dangerous animal born in a keeper's care receives a certificate once the conditions for holding it are met, and the certificate counts as a license.

The license is also where the category meets CITES. Apart from a definition, the treaty appears in the Egyptian regulation only as documents inside the license: the special file, and an approval to display a CITES-listed animal at a show. It plays no part in deciding which animals enter the category. The Egyptian list places the gorilla and the chimpanzee, both in Appendix I of CITES, the treaty's strictest level of protection, in one table with three breeds of dog.

The statutes name no way back for a seized animal, except Qatar's. The Emirati, Bahraini and Egyptian laws send seized animals to shelters and leave what happens next to regulations or to the authority, and the Emirati law also defines euthanasia. Qatar's law, drafted apart from the others, allows the authority to return a seized animal to its original home at the offender's expense.

The Emirati regulation of 2019 goes further. When a seized animal's keeper cannot be traced within fifteen days, the authority may place it in a licensed center, rehabilitate it and return it to its natural environment, or release it in a protected area. Egypt's 2025 regulation keeps a narrower version. It applies only to animals surrendered, within a month of the regulation's entry into force, by keepers who cannot be licensed. It covers only animals native to Egypt, and provides that their return to Egyptian natural habitats is to be considered after the necessary technical and scientific steps. For seized animals in general, neither the Egyptian law nor its regulation names such a route.

In two places, the Egyptian regulation departs from the Emirati regulation it follows: the record of where an animal came from, and the way back for a seized animal.

8 What the Open Lists Allow

None of the four lists is closed. Each law gives a named authority the power to revise its list without new legislation. This section concerns Egypt, where ACB works.

In Egypt, the minister may amend the tables on the proposal of the General Organization for Veterinary Services, by adding species, removing them or moving them between tables, as happened for dogs in May 2025. The license rules sit in the executive regulation, which the Prime Minister issues on the joint proposal of the ministers responsible for veterinary services, the environment and local development. Three points follow, each within one of these powers.

First, the list can show what the category leaves out. When it is next revised, it could record, for each species, whether it is native to Egypt and whether it appears in the CITES appendices. The list would then show two facts that the harm criterion ignores, and that Egypt's own law and regulation already treat as relevant.

Second, the license can ask where an animal came from. The Emirati regulation already requires a register of each animal's purchases and sales, with their sources and proof, and a file of CITES certificates. Adding the same register to the Egyptian regulation, and setting out what its CITES file must contain, would close the gap described in section 7.

Third, the way back can be made permanent. The law requires the regulation to set out the measures that the authorities may take to carry it out. The Emirati regulation allows a seized animal whose keeper cannot be traced to be rehabilitated and returned to its natural environment, or released in a protected area. The Egyptian regulation already provides for considering the return of a native animal to Egyptian natural habitats, but only for animals surrendered in the transitional period after it took effect. The same measure could extend to native animals seized under Article 24 of the law or confiscated under Article 20.

None of these points requires a new law.

Some questions the texts cannot answer. How many licenses have been issued in Egypt, how many animals were surrendered in 2025, where they went, and whether any native animal has been returned to the wild are questions of practice. Answering them needs records.

A way of sorting animals written down in 1900 now decides, in four Arab states, where a wild animal may live. Egyptian law imagines an animal that knows the way back. For a wild animal the state seizes, it has yet to write one.

Annex A. The Definitions Side by Side

The definitions below are quoted from the first article of each law, in the official Arabic texts listed in Annex C. They are grouped by meaning rather than by label, so that each definition stands beside its counterparts even where the laws give it a different name. Rows 5 and 6 show the change of names discussed in section 5. Where a law has no counterpart, the entry says so. Vowel marks may differ from the printed sources; the measurement in Annex B ignores them.

1. The dangerous animal

UAE 2016

الحيوانات الخطرة: الحيوانات التي تحدث نوعاً من الأذى أو الضرر على الإنسان أو الحيوانات الأخرى والمحددة جميعها في الملحقين (1) و(2) من هذا القانون ومنها الحيوانات المفترسة والمهجنة وشبه الخطرة.

Egypt 2023

الحيوانات الخطرة: الحيوانات المحددة بالجدول رقم (١) المرفق بهذا القانون والتي تلحق نوعاً من الأذى أو الضرر بالإنسان أو بالحيوان.

Bahrain 2026

الحيوانات الخطرة: الحيوانات التي تسبب الأذى أو الضرر للإنسان أو الحيوانات الأخرى، ويعتبر من الحيوانات الخطرة الحيوانات المفترسة والحيوانات شبه الخطرة، ويصدر بتحديد هذه الحيوانات قرار من الوزير بعد موافقة مجلس الوزراء.

Qatar 2019

الحيوانات والكائنات الخطرة: الحيوانات والكائنات المنصوص عليها في الجدول المرفق بهذا القانون.

2. Predators

UAE 2016

الحيوانات المفترسة: الحيوانات التي تعتمد في حياتها على اصطياد وأكل لحوم الحيوانات الأخرى.

Egypt 2023 No counterpart.

Bahrain 2026

الحيوانات المفترسة: الحيوانات التي تعتمد في حياتها على اصطياد وأكل لحوم الحيوانات الأخرى.

3. Semi-dangerous animals

UAE 2016

الحيوانات شبه الخطرة: الحيوانات غير الخطرة في طبيعتها والتي تغير سلوكها لتصبح عدائية أو شرسة ويحتمل أن تسبب أذى للإنسان.

Egypt 2023 No counterpart.

Bahrain 2026

الحيوانات شبه الخطرة: الحيوانات غير الخطرة بطبيعتها، والتي تغير سلوكها لتصبح عدائية أو شرسة، ويحتمل أن تسبب أذى للإنسان أو لغيرها من الحيوانات.

4. Hybrid animal

UAE 2016

الحيوان المهجن: الحيوان الناتج من تزاوج حيوانين من فصيلتين أو سلالتين مختلفتين، والمحددة في الملحقين (1) و(2) من هذا القانون.

Egypt 2023 No counterpart.

Bahrain 2026 No counterpart.

5. The animal that nobody owns and that lives on its own

UAE 2016

الحيوان السائب: الحيوان غير المملوك الذي يوجد في موقع ما معتمداً على ذاته وغير خاضع لسيطرة ورعاية أي حائز.

Egypt 2023

الحيوان الضال: الحيوان غير المملوك وغير الخاضع لسيطرة ورعاية أي حائز، ويوجد في موقع ما معتمداً على ذاته.

Bahrain 2026

الحيوان السائب: الحيوان غير المملوك الذي يوجد في موقع ما معتمداً على ذاته وغير خاضع لسيطرة ورعاية أي حائز.

6. The animal that has a keeper but roams free

UAE 2016

الحيوان الضال: الحيوان الذي يتجول بحريته بدون قيد وإشراف من حائزه ولو كان يملك معرفة الرجوع إلى مكان حيازته.

الحيوان المتروك: الحيوان الذي يتجول بحريته خارج مكان إيوائه بدون قيد وإشراف من حائزه ولو كان يملك معرفة الرجوع إلى مكان حياته وإيوائه.

الحيوان الضال: الحيوان الذي يتجول بحريته بدون قيد أو إشراف من حائزه ولو كان يملك معرفة الرجوع إلى مكان حياته.

7. The owned animal left without care

UAE 2016 No counterpart.

Egypt 2023 No counterpart.

الحيوان المتخلي عنه: هو الحيوان المملوك الذي يتركه حائزه عمداً أو عن إهمال بدون قيد أو إشراف، بتركه في مكان عام أو خاص دون توفير للرعاية أو الإيواء اللازمين، ودون اتخاذ الإجراءات القانونية المقررة للتخلي عنه أو نقله أو عدم مقدرة على حياته.

8. Keeper and possession

UAE 2016

حائز الحيوان: الشخص الطبيعي أو الاعتباري الذي يملك أو يحوز أو يحتفظ أو يأوي أو يرعى أو يحرس الحيوانات بشكل دائم أو مؤقت.

Egypt 2023

حائز الحيوان: الشخص الطبيعي أو الاعتباري الذي يملك أو يحوز أو يحتفظ أو يؤوى أو يرعى أو يحرس الحيوانات الخطرة بشكل دائم أو مؤقت.

الحائز: الشخص الطبيعي أو الاعتباري الذي يقوم بحيازة الحيوان الخطر.

الحيازة: تملك أو احتفاظ أو إيواء أو رعاية أو حراسة أو حجز أو توليد أو تربية الحيوان الخطر بأية طريقة كانت، وسواء كان ذلك بشكل دائم أو مؤقت.

9. Trade

UAE 2016

التداول: كافة عمليات البيع أو العرض أو التسويق أو الترويج أو النقل أو الاستيراد أو التصدير أو إعادة التصدير أو المبادلة أو الاستعارة.

Egypt 2023

التداول: جميع عمليات التعامل على الحيوانات الخطرة، وعلى الأخص بيعها أو استيرادها أو تصديرها أو مبادلتها أو استعارتها أو عرضها أو نقل حيازتها أو نقلها من مكان لآخر.

التداول: عمليات البيع أو العرض أو التسويق أو الترويج أو النقل أو الاستيراد أو التصدير أو إعادة التصدير أو المبادلة أو الاستعارة للحيوان الخطر.

10. Breeding

UAE 2016

الإكثار: توالد أو أي نشاط لزيادة توالد الحيوانات الخطرة.

Egypt 2023

الإكثار أو الولادة: أي نشاط لزيادة توالد الحيوانات الخطرة.

الإكثار: توالد أو زيادة توالد الحيوانات الخطرة.

11. Facility

UAE 2016

المنشأة: أي مكان تؤوى أو تحتفظ أو تحجز أو تستولد أو تربي أو تكثر أو تعالج فيه الحيوانات الخطرة.

Egypt 2023 No counterpart.

المنشأة: الأماكن أو الجهات المرخص لها بحيازة أو تداول أو إكثار الحيوانات الخطرة.

12. Zoo

UAE 2016

حديقة الحيوان: المنشأة التي تحوز وتحتفظ وتكثر الحيوانات الحية بغرض العرض والترفيه أو المحافظة على أنواعها أو لأغراض تعليمية أو بحثية.

Egypt 2023 No counterpart.

Bahrain 2026

حدائق الحيوان: منشآت يتم فيها حيازة أو إكثار الحيوانات بغرض العرض والترفيه أو المحافظة على أنواعها أو لأغراض تعليمية أو بحثية.

13. Animal park

UAE 2016

المتنزهات الحيوانية: حدائق ذات مساحة واسعة تتيح للحيوان حرية الحركة وتحاكي بيئته الطبيعية وتمكن الزائر من الزيارة والتجول ضمن مركبات مخصصة.

Egypt 2023

المتنزهات الحيوانية: حدائق ذات مساحة واسعة تتيح للحيوان حرية الحركة وتحاكي بيئته الطبيعية وتمكن الزائر من الزيارة والتجول ضمن مركبات مخصصة.

Bahrain 2026

المتنزهات الحيوانية: منشآت يتاح فيها للحيوانات حرية الحركة وتحاكي بيئتها الطبيعية، وتمكن الزائر من الزيارة والتجول ضمن مركبات مخصصة.

14. Circus

UAE 2016

السيرك: أي مكان يحتفظ فيه بالحيوانات بغرض الترفيه والاستعراض.

Egypt 2023 No counterpart.

Bahrain 2026

السيرك: منشأة يحتفظ فيها بالحيوانات بغرض الترفيه والاستعراض.

15. Euthanasia and identification

UAE 2016

التخلص الرحيم: عملية إنهاء حياة الحيوان بطريقة سريعة وبأقل ألم أو معاناة ممكنة.

UAE 2016

الشريحة الإلكترونية: رقاقة إلكترونية صغيرة يتم تثبيتها تحت الجلد لتعريف الحيوان بأرقام ورموز محددة.

Egypt 2023 No counterpart.

Bahrain 2026 No counterpart.

16. Registers

UAE 2016 No counterpart.

Egypt 2023 No counterpart.

Bahrain 2026

سجل المنشآت: سجل تمسكه الإدارة المختصة بتقيد فيه المنشآت المرخص لها طبقاً لأحكام هذا القانون.

Bahrain 2026

سجل الحيوانات الخطرة: سجل تمسكه الإدارة المختصة بتقيد فيه الحيوانات الخطرة.

17. Dogs

UAE 2016 No counterpart.

Egypt 2023

الكلاب: الكلاب غير الخطرة التي يجوز الترخيص بحيازتها طبقاً للفصل الثالث من هذا القانون، شريطة أن تخرج عن نطاق الفصائل الكلبية الخطرة.

Egypt 2023

مصطحب الكلب: كل شخص يملك السيطرة الفعلية على الكلب خارج حدود أماكن إيوائه ولو لم يكن مالكاً له.

Bahrain 2026 No counterpart.

18. Who runs the law

UAE 2016

الوزارة: وزارة التغير المناخي والبيئة.

UAE 2016

السلطة المختصة: السلطة المحلية المعنية في كل إمارة.

Egypt 2023

السلطة المختصة: الهيئة العامة للخدمات البيطرية.

Egypt 2023

الوزير المختص: الوزير المعنى بشئون الخدمات البيطرية.

Bahrain 2026

الوزارة: الوزارة المعنية بشئون الثروة الحيوانية أو الجهة التي يصدر بتسميتها مرسوم.

Qatar 2019

الوزارة: وزارة البلدية والبيئة.

Annex B. Measurement Data

Texts. For each law we took the provisions listed in Table B1, from the official texts listed in Annex C. For Egypt we used the text of the Official Gazette. The official Emirati text is a PDF whose conversion to text broke some Arabic letters apart; we corrected them by hand and checked every corrected passage against the official file.

Preparation. We removed vowel marks, the elongation mark, punctuation and list markers, and wrote each letter that has more than one form in a single form: every form of alif as bare alif, alif maqsura as ya, ta marbuta as ha, and hamza on waw or ya as the bare letter. Digits and non-Arabic characters were removed, and words were separated at spaces.

Measure. For a later law B and an earlier law A, we listed every distinct run of five consecutive words in B and counted the share that also appears, in the same order, somewhere in A. The measure is directional: it describes how much of B is found in A. As a check, we repeated the count with runs of three words. We also recorded the longest run of consecutive words that the two texts share.

Reading the figures. “n/a” marks a provision that one of the two laws does not contain. Shared runs between laws drafted apart stay short and formulaic; the longest, ten words between Bahrain and Qatar, is the standard opening of a definitions article. Egypt’s law shares a single seven-word phrase with Qatar’s, in the rule that issues a certificate for each dangerous animal born; that is too little to call a transplant.

Definitions. Egypt’s eleven definitions are short, so Table B5 reports runs of three words. A definition counts as containing Emirati text when it shares at least five consecutive words with the Emirati definitions.

Size. After preparation, the nine provisions contain 875 words in the Emirati law, 329 in the Qatari law, 830 in the Egyptian law and 1,001 in the Bahraini law.

Table B1. The provisions compared

Provision	UAE 2016	Qatar 2019	Egypt 2023	Bahrain 2026
Definitions	Art. 1	Art. 1	Art. 1	Art. 1
Ban and license	Arts. 3, 4	Art. 2	Art. 2	Arts. 3, 4, 5
Keeper's duties	Arts. 5, 6	Art. 5	Arts. 4, 5	Art. 6
Public's duty to report	Arts. 8, 9	none	Art. 8	Art. 7(a)
Keeper's duty to notify	Art. 10	Art. 4 (deaths, losses)	Art. 6	Art. 8
Births	none	Art. 4 (births, certificate)	Art. 7	none
Seizure	Art. 11	Art. 6	Art. 24	Art. 7(b), (c)
Public places	Art. 16	Art. 3	Art. 3	Art. 9
Penalties for an attack	Arts. 17, 18	Art. 8	Art. 17	Arts. 10, 11(1)

Table B2. Shared text across all nine provisions

Later law, earlier law	Five-word runs	Three-word runs	Longest shared run (words)
Egypt 2023 from UAE 2016	9%	18%	21
Bahrain 2026 from UAE 2016	20%	30%	27
Bahrain 2026 from Egypt 2023	6%	12%	14
Qatar 2019 from UAE 2016	1%	7%	6
Egypt 2023 from Qatar 2019	1%	5%	7
Bahrain 2026 from Qatar 2019	1%	4%	10

Table B3. Shared text by provision (five-word runs)

Provision	Egypt from UAE	Bahrain from UAE	Bahrain from Egypt	Qatar from UAE	Egypt from Qatar	Bahrain from Qatar
Definitions	22%	26%	5%	5%	0%	2%
Ban and license	9%	7%	4%	0%	0%	0%
Keeper's duties	9%	13%	3%	0%	0%	0%
Public's duty to report	0%	10%	50%	n/a	n/a	n/a
Keeper's duty to notify	6%	10%	7%	0%	0%	0%
Births	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	6%	n/a
Seizure	0%	18%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Public places	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
Penalties for an attack	2%	34%	2%	2%	2%	2%

Table B4. The longest shared run for each pair

Pair	Words	Run, in the original spelling
Egypt from UAE	21	المتنزهات الحيوانية: حدائق ذات مساحة واسعة تتيح للحيوان حرية الحركة وتحاكي بيئته الطبيعية وتمكن الزائر من الزيارة والتجول ضمن مرجبات مخصصة
Bahrain from UAE	27	الحيوان السائب: الحيوان غير المملوك الذي يوجد في موقع ما معتمداً على ذاته وغير خاضع لسيطرة ورعاية أي حائز. الحيوان الضال: الحيوان الذي يتجول بحريته بدون قيد
Bahrain from Egypt	14	وعلى كل من يعلم بوجود حيوان خطر غير مرخص بمحاذاة له أي حائز، إبلاغ
Qatar from UAE	6	أو بإحدى هاتين العقوبتين، كل من
Egypt from Qatar	7	خطر يولد شهادة تتضمن البيانات الخاصة به
Bahrain from Qatar	10	في تطبيق أحكام هذا القانون، تكون للكلمات والعبارات التالية المعاني

Table B5. Egypt's eleven definitions measured against the Emirati definitions

Egyptian definition	Three-word runs found in the Emirati definitions	Longest shared run	Contains Emirati text
Dangerous animals الحيوانات الخطرة	20%	5 of 17 words	yes
Keeper of the animal حائز الحيوان	70%	11 of 22 words	yes
Trade التداول	0%	2 of 27 words	no
Breeding or birth الإكثار أو الولادة	100%	6 of 6 words	yes, word for word
Stray animal الحيوان الضال	50%	6 of 16 words	yes
Abandoned animal الحيوان المتروك	68%	13 of 21 words	yes
Dogs الكلاب	5%	3 of 21 words	no
Person accompanying a dog مصطحب الكلب	0%	1 of 16 words	no
Animal parks المتنزهات الحيوانية	100%	19 of 19 words	yes, word for word
Competent authority السلطة المختصة	0%	0 of 4 words	no
Competent minister الوزير المختص	0%	1 of 5 words	no

Annex C. Sources

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Note on the 2025 amendment

Decree No. 218 of 2025 amended the tables attached to Law No. 29 of 2023 by replacing them with tables attached to the decree. We could not find those attached tables online as text. For the list as amended, this paper relies on three sources: the decree's operative text; the statement of the Council of Ministers of 7 May 2025 that its review of the lists cut the dangerous dog breeds from sixteen to three and allowed twenty-seven breeds to be licensed and registered; and the schedule of license fees in Decree No. 1731 of 2025, published six days after the amendment, which still prices licenses for great apes, wild asses, big cats, hyenas, bears and other wild groups.

"ولو كان يملك معرفة الرجوع": كيف انتقلت فئة "الحيوان الخطر" بين القوانين العربية

يسمي القانون المصري نوعاً من الحيوانات "متروكاً"، ثم يعرفه دون أي إشارة إلى الترك. تتبعنا هذا الدليل عبر أربعة قوانين عربية لتنظيم حيازة الحيوانات الخطرة: الإمارات سنة ٢٠١٦، وقطر سنة ٢٠١٩، ومصر سنة ٢٠٢٣، والبحرين سنة ٢٠٢٦.

قسنا ما تشترك فيه هذه القوانين من نصوص. قسمنا كل قانون إلى تسعة أحكام قابلة للمقارنة، وحسبنا نسبة العبارات المكونة من خمس كلمات التي وردت بحروفها في قانون أسبق.

صاغ القانون القطري مستقلاً عن القوانين الثلاثة الأخرى، وتبقى النصوص المشتركة بينه وبين كل منها في حدود ١٪، وهذه هي نقطة المقارنة. أما القانون المصري فيشارك مع القانون الإماراتي في ٩٪ من النص المقيس، وفي ٢٢٪ من التعريفات. ستة من تعريفاته الأحد عشر تتضمن نصاً إماراتياً، واثنان منها منقولان بحروفهما. ويشارك القانون البحريني مع الإماراتي في ٢٠٪ من النص المقيس. وفي حكم واحد، هو واجب الإبلاغ عن الحيوان الخطر، أخذ القانون البحريني بالصياغة المصرية لا بالأصل الإماراتي. انتقل النص من الإمارات إلى مصر والبحرين، وانتقل حكم واحد على الأقل من مصر إلى البحرين.

والفئة التي تجمع هذه القوانين أقدم منها جميعاً. فاتفاقية لندن لسنة ١٩٠٠، التي وقعت القوى الاستعمارية الأوروبية ولم تدخل حيز النفاذ، سعت إلى حماية الحيوانات البرية التي رأتها نافعة للإنسان أو غير ضارة، وأدرجت حيوانات أخرى على أنها ضارة ينبغي تقليل أعدادها. وسبع من مجموعاتها الضارة العشر واردة في القائمة المصرية لسنة ٢٠٢٣. أما الغوريلا والشمبانزي والمارموس، وقد أدرجتها الاتفاقية للحماية لندرتها، فهي اليوم في القائمة المصرية ذاتها مع ثلاث سلالات من الكلاب.

وتجيب هذه القوانين عن الحيوان الخطر بالترخيص. ففي القوانين الإماراتية والمصرية والبحرينية، يجوز الترخيص لحداثي الحيوان والمتنزهات الحيوانية والسيرك بحيازة هذه الحيوانات وإطعامها وتداولها. وتبع اللائحة التنفيذية المصرية لسنة ٢٠٢٥ اللائحة الإماراتية لسنة ٢٠١٩ عن قرب، لكنها تختلف عنها في موضعين. فهي لا تتضمن السجل الإماراتي الذي يثبت مصدر كل حيوان. وهي تقصر الطريق الإماراتي لعودة الحيوان المضبوط، أي تأهيله وإعادةه إلى بيئته الطبيعية، على حيوانات البيئة المصرية التي سلّمت خلال فترة انتقالية.

ويملك الوزير أو الوزارة المختصة في كل من الدول الأربع تعديل القائمة، وقد عدّلت مصر قائمتها سنة ٢٠٢٥، ولذلك نتصل هذه النتائج بالتعديل القادم.